

Edinburgh Castle (Kids)

UK Family Tour

The Most Attacked Castle in Britain

You're climbing onto the plug of an extinct volcano — the same one from this morning's walk — and on top of it sits the most besieged castle in Britain. Edinburgh Castle has been attacked at least twenty-six times in its history. Everybody wanted it, because whoever held this rock held Scotland's capital. The cliffs protect it on three sides; the only way in is the way you're walking, up the tail of the volcano — which is why every defense faces this direction. The sneakiest capture happened in 1314, during the Wars of Independence, when the castle was held by the English. A Scot named Thomas Randolph had a secret weapon: a soldier called William Francis who, years earlier, had lived in the castle and had secretly climbed down the "impossible" north cliffs at night to visit his girlfriend in town. He knew a hidden route up the rock face. So thirty men climbed the cliff in the dark, hauled up ladders, popped over the wall, and took the castle from the inside. All because of a young man sneaking out to see his girlfriend. As you cross the drawbridge, look for the statues of William Wallace and Robert the Bruce guarding the gate — Scotland's two greatest heroes, whose stories you'll hear more of at Stirling in two days.

Tell Me More: Sieges, Dogs and a Piper

More castle stories. The castle has its own soldiers' dog cemetery — a tiny garden on the ramparts where regiments buried their mascots and officers' dogs for a hundred and fifty years, with little headstones you can see from above. Soldiers take their dogs seriously here. The castle also has a legend about a lone piper: long ago, the story goes, a secret tunnel was discovered running from the castle down under the Royal Mile, and a piper boy was sent in to explore, playing his bagpipes as he went so those above could track his progress under the street. The music moved down the Mile... then stopped, somewhere around the Tron, and the boy was never seen again. People claim you can sometimes still hear faint piping under the street. (Take this one with a large pinch of salt — but it's a good one to retell at dinner.) Real history that sounds fake: during World War One, the

castle vaults held prisoners of war, and one German prisoner made a daring escape by hiding in a cart — the vaults still have graffiti carved by prisoners, including a carving of a ship made by a French prisoner two hundred years ago, and there's even a record of prisoners forging fake money in here. And in World War Two, the Honours — the crown jewels you're about to see — were buried again, this time right here inside the castle, in case of Nazi invasion. Only a handful of people knew the exact spots. The crown spent the war under a medieval toilet closet. True.

The Volcano Under Your Feet

Let's go back in time, way, way back, further than knights and castles, further than the Romans, all the way to when this rock was born. About three hundred and forty million years ago, long before there were dinosaurs, there was no castle here and no city, just a bubbling volcano. Deep underground, red-hot melted rock pushed up toward the surface through a crack in the earth. But here's the surprising part. This volcano never had a big dramatic eruption that you'd draw with orange lava pouring down the sides. Instead the molten rock got stuck in the volcano's throat, cooled down slowly, and turned rock-hard, like a plug jammed in the neck of a bottle. That plug is what you're standing on. It's some of the toughest, hardest rock in the whole region.

Now spin the clock forward, millions and millions of years, to the ice ages. Imagine a sheet of ice so thick it would bury this entire castle, taller than the tallest building you've ever seen, grinding very slowly across the whole of Scotland from west to east. That ice was like a giant sheet of sandpaper. It scraped away all the soft rock around here, wearing the land down flat. But when the ice reached this hard volcanic plug, it couldn't grind it away. The plug was too tough. So the ice split and flowed around it, and everything in the sheltered space behind the rock, tucked in its shadow, was protected.

That's why the shape of this whole hill is so strange, and so useful for a castle. On one side you have this steep cliff of hard old volcano, the "crag." And stretching away behind it, going gently downhill, is a long ramp of the softer rock that

the ice couldn't quite reach, the "tail." Grown-ups call the whole shape a crag and tail. You already walked up the tail this morning, all the way up the Royal Mile. Think about that. A river of ice, thousands of years ago, decided exactly where Edinburgh's most famous street would go. The castle sits up on the crag with cliffs on three sides, and the town trails down the tail behind it. Fire made this rock. Then ice carved it into the perfect throne for a fortress.

The Tiny Oldest Building

Somewhere near the top of the castle there's a little stone building so small you might walk right past it. It only holds about twenty people squeezed in tight. But look closely, because this plain little box is the oldest building in the whole city of Edinburgh. It's called Saint Margaret's Chapel, and it has been standing here for almost nine hundred years, since around the year eleven thirty. That means it was already old when knights in armor were still a new idea. Every other building on this rock has been smashed and rebuilt, again and again, but this tiny chapel somehow survived it all.

Here's why it's still standing. Remember the sneaky night attack in thirteen fourteen, when Scottish soldiers climbed the cliffs and took the castle back from the English? Afterward, Robert the Bruce gave a harsh order. He said tear the castle down, knock over the walls, so the English can never use it against us again. His soldiers wrecked nearly everything. But when they came to this one small chapel, they stopped. It was a holy place, and even in the middle of a war, they left it alone. So while mighty towers and thick walls were flattened into rubble, the smallest, humblest building on the rock was spared, and that's exactly why it outlived them all.

The chapel is named after a queen. Her name was Margaret, and she lived even before the chapel was built. She was actually an English princess who fled north to Scotland long ago and married a Scottish king called Malcolm. People said she was extraordinarily kind, that she fed poor children with her own hands and gave away her money to anyone in need. After she died, the church declared her a saint. Her son, King David, built this little chapel high on the rock in her memory, so people could pray there and remember his mother. And here's a strange twist. Over the centuries everyone forgot what the building even was. For years soldiers used it as a storeroom for gunpowder, of all things, until someone finally realized this dusty little shed was a royal chapel nearly seven hundred years old. Step inside if you can. You're standing in the oldest room in Edinburgh.

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BANG! The One O'Clock Gun

If it's almost one o'clock, get ready — and maybe cover your ears. Every day except Sunday, a real artillery gun is fired from the castle walls at exactly 1 PM, and it has been happening since 1861. Tourists jump. Locals don't even blink — spotting who flinches is how Edinburghers identify visitors. Why fire a gun at lunchtime? Same reason as the red ball you saw drop in Greenwich: time for ships. Sailors in the harbor of Leith needed an exact signal to set their clocks for navigation. Edinburgh built both — a time ball on a monument AND a gun, because on foggy days you can't see a ball drop, but you can always hear a cannon. And why one o'clock instead of twelve, like other cities? The joke Edinburghers tell on themselves: firing one shot instead of twelve saves eleven cannonballs' worth of gunpowder — classic Scottish thrift. There used to be an amazing detail: since sound travels slowly, a map was published showing how many seconds to add depending how far you lived from the castle. People across the sea in Fife added around fifteen seconds. Nearby, meet Mons Meg, a monster cannon from 1457 that could hurl a stone cannonball heavier than a grown man about three kilometers. Stick your head near the barrel — it's half a meter wide.

Tell Me More: Gun Stories

Gun stories, collected. The One O'Clock Gun has had famous gunners — the longest-serving, "Tam the Gun," fired it for over twenty-five years and became a city celebrity; the first female gunner took over in the two thousands. The gun has been fired by special guests, has appeared in countless movies of people jumping, and once, during a power cut, had to be fired using an old-fashioned backup method, because the one o'clock BANG simply cannot be late — Edinburghers set their watches by it and would notice. During the World Wars the gun fell silent (a cannon firing daily over a city at war sends the wrong message), and when it returned, crowds came to celebrate the BANG coming back. Now, Mons Meg: when she was young, in 1497, King James the Fourth dragged her to besiege an English castle — moving her took a hundred men and reportedly crushed roads as she went, at a top speed of about five kilometers a day. Slower than you walk. Her cannonballs were so huge that some fired in tests centuries ago were later found kilometers away and are displayed beside her. When she burst firing a birthday salute in 1681, an eyewitness suspected the English-made gunpowder charge — a Scottish gun could never fail

on its own, obviously. She lay retired in the Tower of London for decades until Sir Walter Scott — the same writer who found the lost crown jewels — campaigned to bring her home. Edinburgh threw her a parade.

Inside the Great Hall

Not everything at the castle is about cannons and cliffs. Step into the Great Hall and look up, all the way up, at the ceiling. It's made of enormous curved beams of dark oak, fitted together without a single nail, like the upside-down hull of a wooden ship. Builders finished it more than five hundred years ago for King James the Fourth, the same king who once dragged Mons Meg off to war. This was the castle's grand party room, where kings held feasts, banquets, and important meetings, with roaring fires, roasted meat, music, and long tables packed with guests in their finest clothes.

Now look around the walls. They're covered, absolutely bristling, with weapons and armor. There are long pikes taller than a grown man, swords, shields, and suits of shining metal armor arranged in patterns, as if the whole room is showing off its muscles. A full suit of that armor could weigh as much as you do, and knights had to be trained for years just to move and fight while wearing it. Imagine walking, let alone swinging a sword, dressed in a metal suit heavier than a big backpack full of bricks.

But here's the best secret in the room, and you have to hunt for it. High up on one wall, near the fireplace, there's a small hidden opening. It's called the laird's lug, which is an old Scots way of saying the lord's ear. The story goes that the king could sit in a little private room next door and listen in through that gap, secretly spying on the conversations of his guests in the hall below. So while everyone was chatting and feasting, thinking they were alone, the king might have been right there behind the wall, quietly hearing every word. Were they plotting against him? Were they being loyal? He wanted to know. See if you can spot the laird's lug from down on the floor. And next time you think you're having a private conversation, remember the kings of Scotland, and check the walls for secret ears.

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The Hidden Crown and the Stolen Stone

Scotland's Crown Jewels — the Honours of Scotland — are older than England's, and they've spent a surprising amount of time buried. When Oliver Cromwell invaded in the 1650s, he'd already melted down England's crown jewels and came for Scotland's next. So Scots smuggled the crown,

sword and scepter out of a besieged castle — one story says lowered down the castle wall and carried off hidden in a bundle — and buried them under the floor of a small country church for nine years. Cromwell never found them. Then, after Scotland and England joined parliaments in 1707, the Honours were locked in a chest in this castle and simply... forgotten. For over a hundred years. In 1818, the writer Sir Walter Scott got permission to break open the sealed room, and there they were, wrapped in linen, exactly where they'd been left. Next to them sits an ancient block of sandstone: the Stone of Destiny, on which Scottish kings were crowned for centuries — until an English king stole it in 1296 and put it under his throne in London, where it stayed for seven hundred years. In 1950, four Scottish students stole it BACK from Westminster Abbey on Christmas Day, accidentally breaking it in two, and hid it for months. England finally returned it officially in 1996. It still travels to London for coronations. It's a very well-traveled rock.

Tell Me More: The Student Heist of 1950

The 1950 Stone of Destiny heist deserves the full story, because four students really did out-plan a kingdom. Ian Hamilton, a law student, and three friends drove from Glasgow to London in two small cars on Christmas Eve. Ian hid inside Westminster Abbey to unlock a door from within — a cleaner found him and, incredibly, just threw him out, assuming he was a tramp. So they broke in through a side door instead, at four in the morning. The Stone weighs a hundred and fifty two kilograms; as they hauled it from under the Coronation Chair, it slipped — breaking off a corner and, according to Ian, nearly crushing his toes. They loaded the big piece into one car, the broken corner into the other, and drove off — at one point a policeman knocked on the window while the Stone sat hidden under a coat on the back seat; the two students pretended to be a courting couple, chatted cheerfully with the officer, and drove away. Roadblocks went up across Britain; the border was watched for the first time in centuries. The students had guessed this — so they first drove SOUTH, hiding the Stone in a field in Kent for two weeks, then came back for it when the fuss died down. It was repaired by a sympathetic stonemason and finally left, wrapped in a Scottish flag, at Arbroath Abbey — where Scotland's independence was declared in 1320. Nobody went to jail; prosecuting them would have been too embarrassing, and too popular. Ian Hamilton became a respected lawyer and never regretted a thing.

The Baby Prince Born on the Rock

Here's something amazing about this castle. A real baby was born up here on the rock, and that baby grew up to become king of not one country but two. It happened on the nineteenth of June, in the year fifteen sixty-six. The baby's mother was one of the most famous people in all of Scottish history, Mary, Queen of Scots. Find the royal apartments and look for the tiny room where it happened. It's astonishingly small, barely bigger than a cupboard, with a low ceiling and one little window looking out over the whole city far below. Imagine, a future king came into the world in a room you could cross in three steps.

But this was not a happy, peaceful time, and the story has real danger in it. Mary's life was full of enemies and plots. Just three months before the baby was born, a gang of armed men had burst into her dinner and murdered her private secretary right in front of her, while she was heavily pregnant. People whispered that the shock might harm the baby. And Mary's own husband, the baby's father, was jealous and cruel, and he even spread a horrible rumor that the child wasn't really his son. Mary was so upset and so determined to prove him wrong that, the story goes, she held the newborn baby up and swore in front of witnesses that this was the king's true son and no one else's.

That little baby was named James. And what a life he had ahead of him. When he was just thirteen months old, younger than almost any baby you know, his mother was forced off her throne, and tiny James was crowned King of Scotland while he was still a toddler who couldn't even walk properly. He never saw his mother again after he was a baby. But the truly astonishing part comes later. Many years on, when the Queen of England died with no children of her own, they looked around for who should be the next ruler, and the answer was James, the baby born in this little castle room. So he became King James the Sixth of Scotland and King James the First of England, at the very same time, ruling both countries at once. All of that, beginning in a room up here no bigger than a closet.

Where the Stone Is Now

Now here's a twist you need to know before you go looking. When you stand in the Crown Room and see the shining crown, the sword, and the scepter, you might expect the famous Stone of Destiny to be sitting right there beside them, the way it was for many years. But it isn't there anymore. The old grey block of sandstone has moved house. Just two years ago, in the spring of twenty twenty-four, the Stone of Destiny left Edinburgh Castle and travelled to a brand-new museum in a town called Perth, about an hour north of here. So if you were hoping to see it today at the castle, that's the puzzle. It has gone.

Why did it move? Well, the Stone actually belongs, deep in history, to that part of Scotland. Long, long ago, before it was ever stolen away to London, Scottish kings were crowned sitting on this stone at a place called Scone, which is right next to Perth. So after seven hundred years of the Stone being carried off, first to England and then to this castle, people decided it should finally go back home to the region it came from. They built it a special new room in the Perth Museum, and enormous crowds came to see it when the museum opened. It was the first time in more than seven centuries that the Stone had returned to its true home ground.

Don't feel too sad about missing it, though, because there's still plenty of magic in that Crown Room without it. And here's the thing to remember about this well-travelled rock. Even now, even in its new home in Perth, the Stone isn't allowed to just sit still and rest. When a new king or queen is crowned, the Stone still has to make the long journey all the way south to London, so the new monarch can be crowned above it, just as monarchs have been for centuries. The very last time that happened was in twenty twenty-three, when King Charles was crowned, and the Stone travelled down for the ceremony and then came straight back to Scotland afterward. So this ancient block of sandstone, older than the castle itself, is still going on adventures. It just does it from Perth now.